Stallings Family History

In July 2009, my Grandma Zoglman passed away at the age of 90. Grandma was born in Waterflow New Mexico on March 5, 1919; seven years after New Mexico became a State. Her Father, Legora Troosten Stallings, or L.T., ran a Trading Post next to a Navajo Indian Reservation. Grandma had an interest in History and often told us stories about her adventures in New Mexico. My Father Bill Schmitt along with my Brothers and I were always interested in Grandma's life in New Mexico. Around 1976 my Aunt Rosie and her family took Grandma and Grandpa Zoglman to New Mexico to visit her home for the first 14 years of Grandma's life. My Dad wanted to visit New Mexico after he retired. To celebrate my Dad's 70th Birthday, my Mom surprised him by sending us four boys and him to New Mexico. Of course, we could not go this adventure and quest without my Mom's youngest Brother Ed Zoglman. On November 1, 2014 Nathan, Ed, my Dad and I flew out of Evansville, Todd out of Chicago, and Luke out of Indianapolis and met in Albuquerque to visit and learn of the Stallings family in New Mexico. Our cousin Keith Stratman joined us Sunday and stayed with us until Monday. Keith drove down from Denver. Keith had been to Waterflow with Grandma in 1976 and could remember several things.

The beginning of the Stallings adventure began in England in the 1600's. It is my understanding that the Stallings family, like many Catholic families, left England for the colony of Maryland. I am unsure when they left England. Maryland was seen as a refuge for many Catholics leaving England. Over the next two centuries the Stallings family migrated west by the end of the 1800's were settled in West Louisville Kentucky, in Daviess County near Owensboro. William Martin Stallings was born February 18, 1848. Lucy Ann Coomes was born October 28, 1855. On February 22, 1873, William and Lucy were married. Together they had 12 Children:

1. Mary Lorena born Dec. 22, 1873 died Aug. 22, 1954
2. Leo Gustave born Nov. 1, 1875 died Feb. 10. 1876
3. Joseph Alphonsus born Dec. 15, 1876, died Oct. 9, 1917
4. Paul De Lacy born April 13, 1879, died Oct. 14, 1947
5. Laurence Lorenzo born May 9, 1881, died Dec. 10, 1954
6. Mary Loretta born Sept. 4, 1883, died Aug. 6, 1969
7. Legora Troosten born Feb. 11, 1886, died May 26, 1959
8. Corilla Jane Stallings born May 8, 1888, died Jan. 27, 1951
9. Emanuel Borgia born Oct. 31, 1890, died Oct. 24, 1953
10. Felix Damien born Jan. 12, 1893, died Feb. 7, 1969
11. Walter Guy born May 11, 1895, died May 9, 1951
12. Lottie Burdel, born Aug. 27, 1897

Unfortunately, William died November 30, 1897 at the age of 48. His youngest daughter Lottie, was only 3 months old. One would assume his death left Lucy and her children in a difficult situation.

It is my understanding that the family remained on the farm William owned. I assume his children helped run the farm.

By 1906 Joseph Stallings, 29, and his younger Brother Lorenzo, 25, migrated west. They arrived in Ft. Smith Arkansas on May 1, 1906 according to the Book "Candles of the Lord". At Ft. Smith they met a young man David Watson who was originally from Georgia. Watson had been in Ft. Smith for some time and was ready to leave when he met the Stallings Brothers. The three became friends and Watson stayed. The three worked for the "City Street Railway Company." It was their intention to save money to migrate to New Mexico to seek economic opportunities. While in Ft. Smith the Stallings Brothers began attending a Catholic Mission Church. Watson, a Baptist, began attending with them and converted to Catholicism.

After about a year, the three friends moved to Pueblo Colorado and lived and worked for about a year. Lorenzo moved to New Mexico first. He teamed up with Joseph and Watson in Moriarity, which is located in Torrance County southeast of Albuquerque. It should be noted that this is the opposite side of the State from Waterflow which is in the Northwest corner. I do not know the connection to this area since there were other transportation routes and sources north. It may be possible Lorenzo had found work in this area.

In late fall of 1909 the three moved to San Juan County, New Mexico. They settled 15 miles west of Farmington on a mesa located on the San Juan River. Farmington is a community of about 40,000 today located by the Navajo Indian Reservation. It is about 7000 feet above sea level what would be the foothills of the Rocky Mountains. The main industry is coal mining that supports the Four Corners Power Plant along with oil, gas, tourism, and some livestock.

According to the "History of Sacred Heart Parish of Farmington", on April 28, 1900 Archbishop Peter Bourgard of Santa Fe established a New Mission Parish in San Juan and Rio San Juan counties. In 1905 the railroad was extended from Durango, Colorado, to Farmington. This provided settlors an easier method of transportation to the Farmington area. In 1908 Father Garnier became the first Pastor of Sacred Heart Parish of Farmington. However, the overseeing of the Parish by Priests from the Santa Fe Diocese was short lived. In 1910 The Franciscan Provincial in Cincinnati agreed to take over the San Juan County Parish and Sacred Heart of Farmington Parish. Father Albert Daeger, OFM, became the First Franciscan Pastor of Sacred Heart Parish and served from 1910 to 1916. While visiting the Church we learned that many Franciscan Priests suffering from tuberculosis stayed at Sacred Heart Parish to recuperate. The dry climate was used to help them with their illness.

The Farmington Parish covered a massive area, 70 by 125 miles, 8000 square miles. It included 400 Spanish American Families. While the Franciscan Fathers were starting their parish in Farmington, Joe, Lorenzo, and their friend David Watson were building their settlement on the Kentucky Mesa. As Stated they settled 15 miles from Farmington in the late fall of 1909 and lived in the "Dugout" for two years. They started with three horses, $9.00, and a few chickens. They began cattle ranging, farming, and trapping coyotes, bobcats, and other wildlife. By the summer of 1910 a flood had destroyed their corn crop, most of their chickens had died, and they found little luck trapping.

Meanwhile, Franciscan Fathers Albert Daeger and Fintan Zumbahler were building the Farmington parish. Father Albert was born in St. Anne, Indiana in 1872. He became a Friar in Oldenburg, Indiana in 1889 and ordained in 1896 in Franklin County near Batesville. I don't know if the Indiana ties had anything to do with the Stallings Brothers who lived in the Owensboro Rockport area. In 1902 he was assigned to Pena Blanca New Mexico and then was assigned to Farmington. In 1919 he became Archbishop of Santa Fe until his death on December 2, 1932 from falling down a coal chute. I believe Father Daeger baptized my Grandmother, Theresa Zoglman.

Father Marcellus Troester, OFM, was the first Assistant Rector. He was very active with the Navajo Indians teaching them about Catechism and the Catholic faith.

By 1912, the year President Taft admitted New Mexico to the Union (January 1, 1912), the Stallings Brothers were still experiencing tough times. In 1912 Father Fintan and Father Theodore Stephan, OFM, arrived in Farmington. Father Fintan was born in Cincinnati in 1879 and ordained in 1905. He was assigned to St. Michaels in Arizona in 1905. In 1912 he came to the Farmington Parish. By this time the railroad was bringing many Catholics to Farmington. The area was inhabited by the Navajo tribe and later members of the Mormon Church in the late 1800's. However, a strong Catholic presence was being seen. On October 2, 1910 a Parochial School was established in Farmington. Part of the growth was the result of Father Fintan establishing Circuit parishes serving them by horseback. In 1912 there were 26 parishes Father Fintan was visiting by horseback.

Father Fintan befriended the Stallings Brothers and David Watson. Years earlier a prospector named Charles Blanchard who lived on the San Juan River talked to the Franciscans about establishing a church by never pursued it. The Stallings and Watson visited Fintan and discussed establishing a Catholic Colony on the Mesa. On Washington's Birthday, February 22, 1912, Father Fintan celebrated the first Mass in Waterflow at the "Dugout" with Joseph, Lorenzo, and David Watson. In the book "Candles of the Lord", the Mass was compared to the Birth of Christ. The Dugout was similar to the Manger, and the three attendees, were shepherds. The three asked Father Fintan to assist them in their Mission Work. Word spread and many of the neighbors who knew little or nothing about the Catholic Faith began visiting and attending the services held in the "Dugout". After 2 years a framed building was constructed on the Mesa and called "Bachelor's Hall." In 1914 Bachelor's Hall was inhabited by seven young men from Daviess County, Joseph and Lorenzo Stallings, David Watson, a joined by Clyde Drury, Felix Warren, Fred Wethington, and Damien Stallings, the 21 year old Brother of Joseph and Lorenzo.

As I mentioned the Stallings lost their Father. It seems they had a taste for adventure. In the "Candle of the Lord" it compared them to fellow Kentuckian Kit Carson who had adventures in the American Southwest and with the Navajo Nation. Their faith was very important to them. In Ft. Smith church was very important to them. Most young bachelors would be more interested in drinking, gambling and women. Their goal included establishing a Catholic Colony, similar to their ancestors that left England after the takeover of the Protestants and sought refuge in Maryland. It should also be noted that they faced severe hardships. Their Faith and friendship with Fr. Fintan and the Franciscans seemed to be important factors in dealing with the adversity.

In June 1914 Father Fintan and Father Felician Sandford visited the seven bachelors unannounced. Fred Wethington left and returned with a sheep he bought. They slaughtered the sheep and served mutton to their guests. 3 Masses were said in Bachelor's Hall during this visit. I found this interesting since mutton is a common dish in Owensboro.

This is an important time for the Kentucky Mesa. The original adventurers had survived and established a Colony ready to be settled. In June 1914 Catholic Settlors from Daviess County began arriving to join the Seven Bachelor's. The Stallings Brothers' sister, Loretta Stallings Warren and her husband Edgar and son Leo arrived. They were followed on August 20, 1914 by Ben Warren and his wife Ursula Clark Warren. On Christmas Eve, 1914 Fred Wethington's parents Mr. and Mrs. JM Wethington arrived with their children Bertha, Wilbur, and Emmanuel. In January 1915 the Stallings were joined by their Mother Lucy Coomes Stallings, her 20 year old son Damien, and her 18 year old daughter Lottie, who later married Fred Wethington, and 24 year old Emmanuel Stallings. Also arriving were Mr. and Mrs. Gonzaga Wethington. They were soon followed by Mr. and Mrs. Bernard Wethington, Mr. and Mrs. Lucius Clements, Mr. and Mrs. Goebel Thompson, and Mr. and Mrs. Marian Warren. However, the Warrens returned to Kentucky shortly after arriving.

A major contributor to the settlement of the Kentucky Mesa was P.B. McAtee who worked for the Rio Grande Western Railway company. McAtee was a devout Catholic and strong Knights of Columbus Member. He was a good friend of Joseph Stallings. He promoted the migration of Catholic families to this area and assisted them and gave them special treatment as they traveled by rail to Durango Colorado and then to Farmington.

Around this time another member of the Stallings family arrived in New Mexico. Legora Troosten Stallings, known as LT, was born in 1886 in West Louisville Kentucky. His Father William died when he was 11 years old. Along with his siblings they helped his Mother Lucy maintain their farm. In 1907 at the age of 21 he entered the Subacia Monastery in Subacio, Arkansas to study the Priesthood. After two years realizing that this was not his call, he left and joined his brothers Joseph and Lorenzo in Ft. Smith Arkansas. Fortunate for me, before he could leave with Brothers to go to New Mexico he met Alice Massey. She married on January 11, 1911 and returned to Daviess County where they purchased a farm adjacent to his Mother's farm and adjacent to Mt. St. Joseph Academy.

After 3 years in 1914 he sold his farm to the Ursuline Sisters at Maple Mount and along with his Mother and five younger siblings joined his brothers in New Mexico. Before he left it is my understanding that he talked to the Ursuline Sisters about providing teachers for the Catholic Settlement. Supposedly he received a promise that they would provide teachers as soon as he provided a school for them to teach.

The Catholic settlors were farmers, ranchers, and traders with the Navajo Indians. LT developed rheumatic fever in New Mexico. The high attitude also caused him health problems. He sold his farm and livestock in New Mexico and purchased a Navajo Trading Post on the Kentucky Mesa. While applying for a Post Office the name of the Catholic Settlement known as the Kentucky Mesa was

changed to Waterflow. LT managed the Trading Post for 19 years before he sold it to his brother Warren.

The year 1917 was both a joyful and sad year for the Kentucky Mesa. There were 22 Catholic Families that built a brick Church at Waterflow, the Church that still stands today that we visited. It has changed little over the 100 years. The trees in front of the Church may be larger now, but attending Mass on November 5, 2014 was probably little different than my Grandma experienced. Funding for the Church came from the Colonists along with donations from the Catholic Extension Society. On May 16, 1917, Reverend Father Provincial Rudolph Bonner, OFM, delegated by Archbishop Pitiual of Santa Fe celebrated the first Mass. The dream of Joseph, Lorenzo, and Watson became a reality. However, tragedy soon struck the settlement. On October 9, 1917, Joseph Stallings was killed in an Automobile accident in Colorado. He was bringing the Automobile to Waterflow. In our research we were unable to determine the leader of the early settlors. I have a gut feeling Joseph may have been. Along with Lorenzo their arrival in Ft. Smith convinced Watson to remain and converted him to Catholicism. He seemed to be a hard worker, entrepreneur, and devout Catholic. He was no quitter. It also seems like his younger brothers were eager and willing to follow him. I wonder if he helped support his family after his father died and being the oldest surviving son. He did lead the way for his Mother and siblings to settle in Waterflow.

Lorenzo, also known as LL or "Uncle Dock" became a ranch owner and has 4 children Irene, Lucy, Warren, and Frances. David Watson was also a rancher and had one son David Junior. I feel Joseph would have been also successful if he had not passed away.

The new church, Sacred Heart of Waterflow, was a busy center for the Community and Faith. David Watson married Ben Warren's sister Mary. Mary's sisters Irene and Rosabelle visited Waterflow. Rosabelle met Lorenzo Stallings and they were soon married. Damien and Bertha Wethington were the first couple married in the framed church. Emmanuel and Arlie Belle Aders were the first couple to be married in the new Church. Ben Warren's son George was the first child born and baptized in the new Church. JM Wethington's son Emmanuel was the first funeral for the new Church. The young boy suffered from an accidental gunshot wound.

Lucy Stallings was a main leader in Waterflow. She was one of 15 children born to William Peter Coomes. The Coomes family was from Ireland and settled in Bardstown Kentucky. His ancestors were Maryland Catholics that moved to Kentucky. She married William Martin Stallings on February 22, 1873. He died on November 30, 1897, leaving the 42 year old widow with 11 living children. Her goal was to raise "Good Citizens and Good Catholics". She was a Grandma to the families in Waterflow. Before the school was built, students were taught in her home. It is my understanding she lived with or near LT when he ran the trading post. After he returned to Kentucky, she stayed with Walter Stallings, her youngest son who ran the Trading Post and Post office. Grandma Zoglman talked about Lucy. They were very close. I think she probably had many of the qualities my Grandma Zoglman had. She seemed to be a gentle, compassionate, affectionate Grandma who enjoyed spending time with her grandchildren. When my Grandma left New Mexico her Grandma Lucy told her, "This will be the last time I see you on earth, the next time we meet will be in Heaven." Grandma Lucy died on July 10,

1936. Funny as I have read about her it seems like I knew her although she passed 30 years before I was born. However, I think she was like my Grandma and my Mother in her relationship to her grandchildren.

Mr. and Mrs. JM Wethington were "Grandpa" and "Grandma" to the Community. They were a main part of the Community until his death on August 14, 1938 followed by his wife's death a month later September 13, 1938.

Father Fintan has received much of the Credit for bringing the Ursuline nuns to New Mexico and deserves it. However, the Stallings family, and LT Stallings, probably deserve a great deal of credit. The Stallings had ties to the Sisters and it seemed LT negotiated with them when he sold his farm to have them provide teachers. In 1918 Mother Aloysius and Sister Roberta Wethington visited Waterflow. They met with Father Fintan who also suggested a Catholic School in Waterflow and Blanco along with Waterflow. In 1919 nine Ursuline Sisters arrived in Farmington. Six Sisters were divided between Waterflow and Blanco. Sacred Heart Academy was established in Waterflow. The other sisters taught at a public school that was started in Blanco. Of the three sisters that stayed in Farmington one taught, one was a nurse, and one served as a diet aid in the kitchen. If you search for "Ursuline Sisters in Waterflow" you will find pictures of the school and students. A picture of my Grandma that she gave us was taken on the same day. We feel that the picture of several students included her siblings and cousins. You can tell it was the same day due to the dress and looks of Grandma and several other students. The School still stands. It was later a mission and now is inhabited by a family. It seems like the students were able to get a high quality of education especially if you consider the school was in the middle of the wilderness. Many of the Sisters that served were from Southern Indiana and the Owensboro area like Sisters Krampe, Coomes, and Payne.

My Grandma often told us stories about her life in New Mexico. However, she never let us know the risk her Father and Uncles took to establish the Catholic Community. Stories included Brothers Fintan and Mike serving as cowboys working on ranches. She told stories about being thrown off and kicked by horses and livestock. She talked about the Navajos like when they would get a rusty can to collect the blood from a slaughtered calf or sheep to be used for bread. She told the story about the cattle getting loose and running thru town but their long, wide horns prevented them from entering her house due to the more narrow doors. The story that stands out most was the day an Eastern young man visiting became involved with an argument with a tough Navajo Indian. She said that the young man pulled a pistol and shot and killed the Indian. They brought the Indian into her house in which he bled on the rug and died. She said she remembered his eyes. She also stated that she did not want to eat red Jell-O but was a celebrity at school telling her friends the story. She did get in trouble for taking her friends to see the sight without getting permission from the teacher. LT told the young man to leave and turn himself in at the San Juan County Sheriff. However, the Navajo Indians showed up looking for the young man. They were angry that he had left and supposedly threaten to lynch LT.

She also talked about Fruitland, Shiprock and Four Corners.

By 1933 LT's health was so poor that he sold the Trading Post and returned to Kentucky. In 1934 he bought a Hoffman farm near Rockport Indiana. Grandma told us about the trip and stopping in Oklahoma to visit cousins. She told us about the two vehicles loaded with her family breaking down. She recounted the time she joined her cousins and sibling at a CCC camp in Oklahoma and its dances and roller skating. I believe her older sister Mary Olive had already returned to Kentucky. However, the rest of the family traveled in the two vehicles.

LT and Alice returned to New Mexico in 1936 when his Mother passed. Grandma never returned until 1976. LT had 11 children, Mary Olive Dilger, Fintan, Michael, Madeline, Levina, Aloysius, Cecilia, LT Jr., V irginia, Mary Alice, and one that died in infancy. LT was a Third Order Member of St. Francis and was buried in his robe of St. Francis. I am told he was a good natured man who loved his faith, family, and his farm. My Grandma, Mother and Uncle Ed had a great amount of love and respect for LT. Ed always talked about how big he was and his picture taken when Ed received his First Communion. However, Ed was devastated when he found out he was only 5 ft. 9 inches instead of 6 ft. 3 inches Ed had thought. Of course, Todd and Nathan pointed out to Ed that all adults seem big to a 6 year old.

I can remember my Great Grandma Alice Stallings. I did not know her very well but she was nothing like my Grandma, Mom, Aunts or Uncles. However, the descriptions of LT are very similar to them.

This is a rough, crude history of the Stallings Family. I wanted to put something in writing while still fresh in my mind. I hope to soon polish and add more information so future generations will know about their past. I want Ellie and Jobe to know about the Stallings Family and have the special experience of visiting Sacred Heart Church in Waterflow.